> administration and that every individual in the country would be entitled to receive the vaccine. As for the criticism on the credibility of the vaccine, it is now abundantly clear, as India makes such commendable headway in her vaccination drive of having administered over a billion doses—that Indian vaccines are of superior quality with due credit owed to our best scientific minds and competent manufacturers.

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Apart from Dr Paul's Empowered Group 1 report submitted in September 2021 predicting three lakh cases at its peak for the second wave, no scientists in the world had raised any alarms or predictions for the speed, nature and timing of the second wave in India. In fact, in February 2021, with states raising alarms on the mounting costs of maintaining COVID-19-related infrastructure, the experts in the Group had advised states and UTs to undertake careful de-escalation with specific criteria requirements to be met. However, they also advised caution in their report that the nationwide sero-survey carried out in December 2020 showed that 75 per cent of the Indian population was still susceptible and the contagion could make resurgence anytime. This basically debunks the theory that the opposition parties and some sections in the media spread like wildfire that the task force didn't meet even once in 2021 during the peak of the second wave which engulfed the country a few months later. They basically implied that because our scientists in the task force didn't meet, they couldn't advise the government on the imminent second wave. There are two points I want to clarify here: there was no need for the original Dr Paul-led VTF to meet since they had essentially offloaded their responsibilities to NEGVAC, EG1—the empowered group on emergency management plan and strategy, EG4—the empowered group on vaccination (all three helmed by Dr Paul) *and* the most recently constituted EG on vaccine administration chaired by R.S. Sharma. Second, the ICMR-constituted NTF, co-chaired by Dr Bhargava and Dr Paul, met seven times between 1 January 2021 and 15 March 2021, details of which can be found on the ICMR website for those who would like further details on the agenda of their discussions.

Now, let us consider what other scientists studying and following India's COVID-19 journey were saying at the time: Indian media's